

If any of these things goes south, the contingencies in your contract allow you to back out of the purchase without losing your earnest money. Those listed above are pretty typical, since they are complete deal breakers that the buyer should be able to walk away from unscathed.

In a buyer's market, you can include even more contingencies. In a seller's market, not so much. Best not to be too picky if you're up against other people who might start a bidding war on the same house. The fewer contingencies you include in your offer, the easier it is for the seller to accept your offer over another.

Ask your agent for guidance about the market you are in—they should know the sweet spot between protecting your earnest money and writing the strongest offer possible.

Speaking of which...

AN OFFER THEY CAN'T REFUSE

Grab your dumbbells and down a protein shake, because we're about to beef up your otherwise average offer.

It shouldn't surprise you that the seller wants the most money possible in their pocket after all this is done. Who wouldn't? They also want as little hassle as possible during the transaction. If you're in a seller's market, writing a strong offer can be the difference between going under contract or going back to square one. (Yes, your offer might not get accepted. Yes, that means you need start all over again—disheartening but true.)

First of all, before making the offer, you should also ask your agent if they can get any additional information about what is most important to the seller. Some will accept a lower purchase price in exchange for speed and fewer barriers to closing. Others don't have any restrictions and are willing to wait for a buyer who can meet their price and terms. If you're willing to be flexible on certain things the seller wants, you might be able to get a better price overall.

Your agent should also ask about any other offers that might be on the table, and they can even go so far as asking what your offer needs to be competitive. While most listing agents won't reveal all these secrets, they might be willing to drop a crumb or two of information.